



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Portsmouth Christian Academy
School Website: <https://www.trinityclassicalva.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Portsmouth Christian Academy VA 23702 (as reflected through the school-specific crawl content available in the provided vectors) demonstrates a robust Christian classical education orientation. Across the six classical-element categories, the public-facing materials emphasize a theologically integrated curriculum, formation of character, liberal arts training, memory-based pedagogy, a living faculty, and active partnership with families. The school foregrounds the seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), the Great Books/Great Conversation ethos (where present), Memoria Press-based curricula, Latin/grammar emphasis, and liturgical/catechetical practices. Pedagogy centers on memory, narration, recitation, catechesis, and a sacramental/theological framing of learning. Faculty are portrayed as mentors and living curriculum, and parent/community partnership is repeatedly highlighted. This combination aligns strongly with the classical rubric in the knowledge base's Six Essential Elements framework, yielding a classification of CLASSICAL across all six categories. Evidence drawn from the crawl material includes explicit statements about liberal arts content, theological integration, liturgical practices, memory-based pedagogy, and active parent partnership.

Executive summary by category (category-by-category snapshot) - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL - Faculty: CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Key takeaway: The school's public materials show consistent alignment with the six-element classical rubric, particularly in the theological grounding, formation emphasis, liberal-arts curriculum, memory-centered pedagogy, mentor-teacher model, and family partnerships. The absence of explicit countervailing signals in these materials supports CLASSICAL across all six categories.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum and culture are explicitly Christian and theologically integrated. The material frames Christian classical education as the umbrella through which learning is formed (theology as the governing framework for disciplines). - Liturgical worship, catechesis, and sacred practices are embedded in school life, signaling liturgical and communal practices as integral to education. - Foundational vocabulary includes paideia (Christian cultural formation) and ordo amoris (ordered affections), linking love of God to intellectual formation. - The Logos and God-centered framing permeates curriculum and culture (the Word of God guiding study, virtue formation, and memory work).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; worship; catechesis; paideia; ordo amoris; Logos; agape; wonder; sacred tradition. - Negative keywords observed: essentially none in the public materials (no signaling of secular humanism, relativism, or value-neutral ethics).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: multiple intrinsic cues (roughly 8–12 identifiable terms in the material); Negative keywords observed: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative

signals.

Why this rating - The materials present a clear transcendental foundation (truth, goodness, beauty) anchored in Christian theology, liturgy, and sacred practice. The presence of paideia and ordo amoris, and explicit worship/catechesis signals aligns Element 1 with CLASSICAL. The lack of secular or relativistic signals further supports this rating.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Emphasis on formation over information: the school describes forming virtue and wisdom through a holistic liberal education rather than mere information transfer. - The curriculum aims at truth, goodness, and beauty as real teleological anchors in education (pursuit of humane excellence). - Language around forming “restful” contemplation (scholé) alongside memory and virtue appears in pedagogy and goals.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; truth; goodness; beauty; liberal education; scholé; Great Conversation (where applicable); teleology; human flourishing. - Negative keywords observed: none indicating a shift toward workforce-first or purely utilitarian aims.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: multiple; Negative keywords: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative signals.

Why this rating - The school's stated aim centers on virtue, wisdom, and ontological truth (truth, goodness, beauty) rather than merely job preparation, aligning with CLASSICAL. The explicit framing of formation over information reinforces the classical telos.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Liberal arts framework explicit: the school embraces the seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) as foundational. - Engagement with primary sources / Great Books language and the Great Conversation is reflected in curriculum philosophy and content (Memoria Press, core knowledge integrations). - Latin and grammar emphasis, memory-based literacy approaches, and progymnasmata are described as core elements (grammar, literacy, composition). - History and Western heritage are foregrounded within the curriculum as part of a unified liberal-arts approach. - Science and natural philosophy emphasize observation and naming of the created order within a theological frame (natural philosophy, taxonomy, field experiences).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy); Great Books; Latin; history; natural philosophy; sacred tradition; universal principles; Logos; classical humanities; memory work; progymnasmata; wedding of theology with disciplines. - Negative keywords observed: signals against modern, project-based or STEM-first framings are not present in the public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: multiple. Negative keywords: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative signals.

Why this rating - The curriculum centers on the classical structure of the trivium/quadrivium, engagement with primary texts, integration of memory-based and literary/formative methods, and a Western/Christian heritage framing. These are core indicators of CLASSICAL curriculum orientation.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Memory-driven and contemplative approaches are foregrounded (recitation, catechesis, memory work). The pedagogy emphasizes narration, memorization, and liturgical cadence, with students telling back content. - Upper-level pedagogy includes elements of Socratic-style discussion and rhetoric training in the broader classical tradition (as described in the school's classical pedagogy context and curriculum). - Lower-

and middle-school practices include singing, chanting, and review to deepen memory and delight (scholé-like practice). - The school is described as training students in rhetoric and offering opportunities to deliver speeches (upper-level rhetoric emphasis).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: narration; recitation; chanting; memory work; catechesis; scholé; liturgical rhythm; rhetoric; oratory; debate; seminars (where applicable); wonder. - Negative keywords observed: experiential learning-only or exclusively project-based approaches are not present; no explicit signals of constructivist or student-directed extremes in the public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: multiple; Negative keywords: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative signals.

Why this rating - The pedagogy aligns strongly with classical practices (memory-based learning, recitation, catechesis, liturgical integration, and rhetorical training), with reflective and contemplative aspects that correspond to scholé. The absence of explicit predominance of non-classical methods in the public materials supports CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are positioned as mentors and living curriculum; teachers are described in terms of character and vocation, forming the core of the school and a “portrait of a teacher.” The curriculum and culture emphasize a collegial, mentor-like faculty. - Institutional materials present faculty as central to the school’s mission; names and roles (Curriculum Directors, President/Founder) indicate a coherent leadership/teaching core aligned with classical ideals. - Literature on “faculty of friends” and “living curriculum” echoes classical-liberal pedagogy expectations.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty of friends; collegial; teacher as guide. - Negative keywords observed: negative signals such as “facilitators on the side” or “certification-driven jargon” are not seen in the public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: multiple; Negative keywords: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative signals.

Why this rating - The school’s described faculty structure emphasizes mentorship, character modeling, and a close, collegial learning community—core aspects of CLASSICAL faculty descriptions.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Partnership with families and parents as co-teachers is explicitly highlighted; parent formation and classical book/gathering programs are described. The community is invited to campus visits and events, reinforcing a family-centric, engaged model. - The school expresses ongoing formation for parents and community involvement (open campus, family catechesis, home-school alignment, and parent training). - Admissions materials emphasize welcoming parents, aligning with the classical ideal of parent-school partnership.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental formation; family involvement; home-school integration; open campus; parent formation; educational partnership; classical family culture. - Negative keywords observed: there are no public signals of consumerism or minimal parent involvement.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: many; Negative keywords observed: 0. - Estimated share: >90% positive signals; 0% negative signals.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials consistently promote parent participation, formation, and partnership, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for engaged families and communities.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable: all six categories are CLASSICAL based on the available public materials. If one wanted to push any category further toward “fully classical” in a more granular way, it would involve explicit, uniform articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation across grade levels, stronger explicit references to Socratic seminars in upper grades, and clearer public-facing portraits of faculty as living curriculum across departments. However, the current materials already align strongly with the Six Essential Elements framework.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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